

INTRODUCTION

Around 1500, warfare entered a phase of intensive innovation. The growing impact of gunpowder weapons led to a re-evaluation of siege warfare, battlefield tactics, and the training of soldiers. At sea, sailing ships armed with cannon gave Europeans unprecedented control of the seas.

Although military developments varied worldwide, there were certain trends. In 16th-century Japan, for example, commanders realized that peasant footsoldiers, if equipped with firearms and properly disciplined, could be a match for the elite mounted samurai. A similar idea underpinned the strict drills of European musket-armed infantry, who learned to fire in volleys and manoeuvre together on the battlefield. In Europe, the use of massed pikemen became standard: the issue of how to combine muskets and pikes in battle preoccupied European military theorists for a century and a half, before the advent of the bayonet, in the late 17th century, made the issue redundant.

The conquest of the Aztec and Inca empires by small Spanish forces, in the 1520s and 1530s, was atypical of European military achievement – the most effective army in the 16th century was arguably that of the Turkish Ottoman Empire. The largest wars of the 17th century were fought by the Manchu in China, while Europe's incessant religious and dynastic conflicts were stimuli for technological development.

The armoured knight evolved into the cavalryman, armed with pistol and sword. Adapting successfully to the challenge of cannon, fortifications became ever more elaborate, as did the techniques used to besiege them. In the Mediterranean, war fleets still consisted of oared galleys but, in the Atlantic, sailing ships evolved into remarkable weapons platforms, with a single ship mounting as many cannon as an entire land army. Permanent regular armies – drilled, disciplined, and uniformed – eventually replaced the former European military traditions of mercenaries, feudal retainers, levies, and militias. The wealth of increasingly centralized European states sustained these expanding military establishments.

KEY DATES

1500

c.1500

The trace italienne fortification system begins to spread in Europe

1509

Portuguese sailing ships dominate the Indian Ocean, after the Battle of Diu, in the Arabian Sea

1516-17

Possession of cannon and firearms enables the Ottoman Turks to conquer Syria and Egypt

1525

Arquebusers and pikemen play an important role in the defeat of the French by the Spanish, at Pavia, Italy

1526

In India, victory at the Battle of Panipat allows Babur to found the Mughal Empire

1543

Portuguese sailors introduce firearms to Japan

1568

The Dutch Revolt begins a long war of independence against Spanish rule in the Netherlands

1575

Japanese warlord Oda Nobunaga makes decisive use of firearms at the Battle of Nagashino

1503

At Cerignola, in Italy, the Spanish make effective use of cannon and firearms fired from behind field fortifications

1511

The English ship *Mary Rose* is one of first to be built with gunports

1519-21

Spanish Conquistadores under Hernan Cortes destroy the Aztec Empire, in Mexico

1526

The Ottoman army of Süleyman the Magnificent defeats the Hungarians at the Battle of Mohács, in Hungary

c.1530

The matchlock musket comes into use in Europe

c.1560

German horsemen introduce the "caracole" tactic for fighting with wheellock pistols

1571

Muslim and Christian galley fleets clash in the Mediterranean at the Battle of Lepanto

1582

The first mid-ocean naval battle is fought off the Azores between the French and the Portuguese

SÜLEYMAN I – 1494-1566



THE BATTLE OF MOHACS – 1526



THE BATTLE OF NAGASHINO – 1575

